

# Lecture 18

## Algebraic Data Types

CS 12 Team 25.2  
A.Y. 2025–2026, 2<sup>nd</sup> Sem  
Department of Computer Science  
College of Engineering  
University of the Philippines Diliman

# Sanity Check

- Attendance?
- Audible at the back?
- TV(s) on?
  - (we're working on getting the other TV fixed...)
- **Recording?**
- Important announcements?

# Elm Resources

- References
  - <https://guide.elm-lang.org/>
  - <https://elmprogramming.com/>
  - <https://elm-lang.org/examples>
- Online editors
  - <https://ellie-app.com/>
  - <https://elm-lang.org/try>
  - <https://elm-editor.com/>

# Motivating Problem: Data representation

Which type below represents BS CompSci student standing best?

- Freshman, Sophomore, Junior, Senior, Other

```
type Standing = Int
```

```
type Standing = String
```

```
type alias Standing =  
  { isFreshman : Bool  
  , isSophomore : Bool
```

```
, isJunior : Bool  
, isSenior : Bool  
}
```

## Aside: type **VS** type alias

- `type alias`: Gives a new name to an *existing type*
- `type`: Creates a *new type*

# Types as Sets

Types can be defined as sets with values as set members

| Elm type                  | Definition as set                                                       | Cardinality |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| <code>Bool</code>         | <code>{True, False}</code>                                              | 2           |
| <code>Int</code>          | <code><math>[-2^{31}, 2^{31} - 1]</math></code>                         | $2^{32}$    |
| <code>String</code>       | <code>{ "", "hello", "CS 12", ... }</code>                              | $\infty$    |
| <code>(Bool, Bool)</code> | <code>{(False,False),(False,True),<br/>(True,False),(True,True)}</code> | 4           |

# Types as Sets

*Composite type*: Type composed of other types

- Python: Lists, dicts, sets, classes, data classes, unions, etc.
- Elm: Tuples, Lists, Arrays, Dicts, etc.

```
type alias R =  
  { ateBreakfast: Bool  
    , ateLunch: Bool  
  }
```



# Types as Sets

- Possible values:
  - { ateBreakfast = False, ateLunch = False }
  - { ateBreakfast = False, ateLunch = True }
  - { ateBreakfast = True, ateLunch = False }
  - { ateBreakfast = True, ateLunch = True }
- $|R| = 4$

# Product Type

*Product type*: Type formed by composing other types with *AND*

- `type alias R = {ateBreakfast: Bool, ateLunch: Bool}`
  - `Bool AND Bool`
- Cardinality: Product of cardinalities of components
  - $|R| = |\text{Bool}| \times |\text{Bool}|$
  - $|R| = 2 \times 2$
  - $|R| = 4$

# Union of Literal Types

```
Standing = Literal["Freshman"] | Literal["Sophomore"] |  
Literal["Junior"] | Literal["Senior"] | Literal["Other"]
```

- Is Standing a product type?

# Sum Type

*Sum type*: Type formed by composing other types with *OR*

- Union type in Python, tagged unions in Elm (more on this in a bit)
- `type R = Bool | Nothing`
  - `Bool OR Nothing`
- Cardinality: Sum of cardinalities of choices
  - $|R| = |\text{Bool}| + |\text{Nothing}|$
  - $|R| = |\text{Bool}| + 1$

- $|R| = 2 + 1$

- $|R| = 3$

# Back to Motivating Problem

Which type below represents *BS CompSci student standing* best?

- `type Standing = number (|Standing| = ∞)`
- `type Standing = String (|Standing| = ∞)`

# Back to Motivating Problem

Which type below represents *BS CompSci student standing* best?

- ```
type Standing =  
  { isFreshman: Bool  
    , isSophomore: Bool  
    , isJunior: Bool  
    , isSenior: Bool  
  }
```

(|Standing| = 8)

- ```
type Standing = Freshman | Sophomore | Junior | Senior  
  | Other (|Standing| = 5)
```

# Back to Motivating Problem

We prefer most accurate way to represent data (ideally isomorphic with actual set of values)



# Algebraic Data Types

*Algebraic data type*: Type formed by composing other types with *AND* and/or *OR*

- Composed of *sum types* and *product types*
- Usually expressed using tagged unions

# Algebraic Data Types

*Tagged union*: Union type with *tag* that identifies which type is in use

- Also called sum type, discriminated/disjoint union, choice type
- *Tag*: Data that can be used to identify which variant a tagged union value is

# Algebraic Data Types

```
type Standing  
  = Freshman  
  | Sophomore  
  | Junior  
  | Senior  
  | Other
```

What if `Other` needs to include total number of years?

# Tagged Unions in Elm

*Tagged union*: Type that takes on exactly one of several variants

- Sum type

```
type DayOfWeek
  = Sunday
  | Monday
  | Tuesday
  | Wednesday
  | Thursday
  | Friday
  | Saturday
```

# Tagged Unions in Elm

- Variants can also *carry data*:

```
type CrsSectionSlots
  = WithSlots Int
  | Full
  | Overbooked Int
  | Dissolved
```

```
type PageState
  = Loading
  | PageReady PageData      -- Record
  | PageError ErrorData     -- Record
```

# Tagged Unions in Elm

- `Maybe` is implemented as a tagged union:

```
type Maybe a
  = Just a
  | Nothing
```

# Tagged Unions in Elm

- Variants can be initialized:

# Tagged Unions in Elm

```
type CrsSectionSlots
  = WithSlots Int
  | Full
  | Overbooked Int
  | Dissolved

type alias CrsSection =
  { course : String
  , section : String
  , capacity : Int
  , slots : CrsSectionSlots
  }
```



# Tagged Unions in Elm

```
example =  
  { course = "CS 12"  
  , section = "TCD"  
  , capacity = 80  
  , slots = WithSlots 14 }
```

# Pattern Matching

- case statement for destructuring variants:

```
toSlotStr : CrsSection -> String
toSlotStr section =
    let
        toFractionStr num den =
            String.fromInt num ++ " / " ++ String.fromInt den
    in
    case section.slots of
        WithSlots left ->
            "OPEN " ++ toFractionStr left section.capacity
        Full ->
```

```
    "FULL " ++ toFractionStr section.capacity  
    section.capacity  
Overbooked over ->  
    "OVERBOOKED " ++ toFractionStr over section.capacity  
Dissolved ->  
    "DISSOLVED"
```

# Pattern Matching

- `_` as wildcard or to ignore unneeded carried data:

```
hasSlots : CrsSection -> Bool
hasSlots section =
    case section.slots of
        WithSlots _ ->
            True
        _ ->
            False

getWithSlots : List CrsSection -> ListCrsSection
getWithSlots sections =
    List.filter hasSlots sections
```

# Data Modeling Example

*Scenario:* Food ordering application for a restaurant; food items as follows:

- *Tapsilog*
  - Should specify whether vinegar should be included
  - Should specify whether atchara should be included
- *Bottled water*
  - No additional specifications
- *Fries*
  - Should specify dip (ketchup or BBQ sauce)

- *Milk tea*
  - Should specify sugar level (0%, 25%, 50%, 75%, 100%)

How do you represent `FoodItem`?

# Tagged Union Representation

```
type Dip = Ketchup | BBQSauce
```

```
type SugarPercent = Percent0 | Percent25 | Percent50 | Percent75 |  
Percent100
```

```
type FoodItem
```

```
  = Tapsilog { vinegar: Bool, atchara: Bool }
```

```
  | Water
```

```
  | Fries Dip
```

```
  | MilkTea SugarPercent
```

# Exhaustiveness Checking

calculateCost computes the total to be shown to the customer; what is wrong with the implementation below?

```
calculateCost: List FoodItem -> Float
calculateCost items =
  let
    getItemCost: FoodItem -> Float
    getItemCost item =
      if item == Tapsilog then
        150
      else if item == Fries then
```



```
        120
      else if item == MilkTea then
        100
      else
        25
in
List.map getItemCost items
|> List.foldl (+) 0
```

# Exhaustiveness Checking

- Syntax error!

```
calculateCost: List FoodItem -> Float
calculateCost items =
  let
    getItemCost: FoodItem -> Float
    getItemCost item =
      if item == Tapsilog then
        150
      else if item == Fries then
        120
      else if item == MilkTea then
```

```
        100
    else
        25
in
List.map getItemCost items
|> List.foldl (+) 0
```

# Exhaustiveness Checking

- Pattern matching allows unwrapping of tagged unions and exhaustiveness checking:

```
calculateCost: List FoodItem -> Float
calculateCost items =
  let
    getItemCost: FoodItem -> Float
    getItemCost item =
      case item of
        Tapsilog _ ->
          150
```

```
Fries _ ->  
    120  
MilkTea _ ->  
    100  
Water ->  
    25
```

```
in
```

```
List.map getItemCost items  
|> List.foldl (+) 0
```

# Exhaustiveness Checking

- Elm can detect if there is a possible branch missing:

```
getItemCost: FoodItem -> Float
getItemCost item =
    case item of
        Tapsilog _ ->
            150
        Fries _ ->
            120
        MilkTea _ ->
            100
```